

A PRACTICAL GUIDE

Reading the Bible in a *Month*

How I Did It, What I Learned, and the Plan I Used

Read the Bible.

See the Big Picture.

Know the Author.

HEATHER LYN WILSON

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Welcome

Friend,

At the end of last year, I asked God for a word for 2026.

I felt like He gave me the word **intentional**.

As I reflected on the previous year, I realized something. I had read more books than ever before. It was a record year of reading for me. I was flying through novels, leadership books, biographies. I don't really watch tv, I read.

But then the question hit me:

What if I spent as much time reading the Bible as I spent reading novels?

I was regularly spending two to three hours a day reading books. Good books. But books written by people. And I started wondering what would happen if I took that same time and that same energy and pointed it at God's Word.

I have read through the Bible in a year many times. I've read it chronologically, in different translations, with different reading plans. I enjoy a good reading plan.

But this year I wondered: what would it be like to read the Bible in a month?

Not as a study. Not as a checklist. But as a story. As one big picture.

So I did it. And it was eye opening.

This guide is everything I learned, the mistakes to avoid, and the reading plan I used to do it.

One tip before you start: if you are going to be intentional about this, you might as well pick a month with 31 days. Just saying.

I hope it encourages you to try it yourself.

Heather

Why Read the Bible in a Month?

Most Christians know parts of the Bible.

We know David and Goliath. Noah and the Ark. Daniel and the Lion's Den. The Christmas story. The Easter story.

We know the highlights.

But most of us have never sat down and read the whole thing front to back in a short enough window to actually feel the momentum of it.

When you read the Bible in a year, you get maybe three or four chapters a day. That's good. But by the time you get to 2 Kings, you've forgotten what happened in Exodus. The connections fade. The threads get lost. You're reading the Bible in pieces, and it feels like pieces.

When you read it in a month, something is different.

You see patterns you have never seen before. Promises that span centuries suddenly feel connected because you just read both ends of them this week. Characters you thought were unrelated turn out to be part of the same thread. The Old Testament stops feeling like ancient history and starts feeling like the setup for everything that comes after it.

The Bible stopped feeling like 66 separate books and started feeling like one story.

That's why. That is why I read the Bible in a month, although I didn't know it was going to do all that.

So I encourage you, try it. Not because it's impressive. Not because it's a spiritual badge. But because it changed the way I see God's Word. And I think it could do the same for you.

BEFORE YOU START

Mistakes That Will Make You *Quit*

These are the same patterns that can derail you from even the best Bible reading plan. These are the common traps that take people out.

Mistakes That Will Make You Quit

Trying to Study Everything

This is the number one reason people don't finish.

You hit a verse that's beautiful or confusing or convicting and you want to stop and dig into it. You want to pull up a commentary. You want to cross-reference it. You want to journal about it.

Don't.

Not right now. Highlight it. Write it down. Put a star next to it. And keep reading. You will have a Bible full of highlights to come back to when you're done. But if you stop to study every interesting verse, you will not finish. I promise you.

Falling Behind

This is the one that gets people.

Missing one day doesn't feel like a big deal. But one day behind means tomorrow you have to read two days' worth. That feels heavy. So you push it to the next day. Now you're three days behind. And three days not only feels impossible, it is impossible.

That's when people quit.

I knew going in that I could not let this happen. If I fell behind, catching up would mean reading 70 or 80 chapters in a day, and that just wasn't going to happen. So I treated every single day like it mattered. Because it did.

Waiting Until You're in the Mood

Some days you will wake up excited to read. Some days you will not.

Do it anyway.

If you only read when you feel like it, you'll make it a couple days. Reading the Bible in a month is a decision, not a feeling. You decided to do this. That decision carries you on the days your feelings don't.

Mistakes That Will Make You Quit

Not Scheduling Reading Time

If you don't put it on your calendar, it won't happen. Every day has a way of filling itself up. Work. Kids. Errands. Dinner. Netflix. And suddenly it's 10:30 at night and you haven't opened your Bible.

I scheduled two reading blocks every day. Morning and evening. It wasn't always pretty but I knew it had to be intentional if it was going to happen. If I knew I had a packed day, sometimes "morning" was up with the sun with coffee that was too hot to drink. Every night I made sure to look at my calendar for the next day and plan accordingly.

Thinking You Have to Understand Everything

You won't.

There are parts of the Bible that scholars have studied for centuries and still debate. You are not going to crack the code on Ezekiel's wheels in a single sitting. And that is perfectly fine.

Understanding comes in layers. This month, you're laying a first layer. You're getting the big picture. You're seeing the whole story. The deeper understanding will come later, and it will come faster because you've already read the whole thing.

Skiping the Difficult Books

Leviticus. Numbers. Parts of Chronicles. The minor prophets.

I get it. They're hard. They feel slow. But they are still God's Word, and I have been surprised more than once by what God showed me in the sections I wanted to rush through.

Don't skip them. Push through them. Use the audio Bible if you need to. But don't skip them.

What Surprised Me Most

I Finally Understood the Prophets (a Little Better)

I'll be honest. For most of my life, the prophets were the part of the Bible I understood the least. Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, all the minor prophets. I knew they were important. I just didn't always know what they were talking about.

But when I read the Bible in a month, I had just finished Kings and Chronicles. I had just watched Israel walk away from God over and over and over. I had just read about the kings who tore down altars and the kings who built them right back up. I knew exactly what Israel had done.

And then the prophets started talking.

And suddenly they made more sense. I could feel the weight of what God was saying. I understood His anger. I understood His grief. I actually cried one day. I understood why He was pleading with people who refused to listen.

The prophets went from being the part of the Bible I skimmed to the part that broke my heart.

I Saw Jesus Everywhere

I knew Jesus was foreshadowed in the Old Testament. I'd heard pastors teach on it. But reading it all back to back, I couldn't miss it.

The sacrificial system in Leviticus. The Passover lamb. The suffering servant in Isaiah. The promises to David. The prophecies in Zechariah. It was everywhere. Not hidden. Not subtle. Just waiting for me to read fast enough to see the pattern.

By the time I got to Matthew, it didn't feel like starting a new section of the Bible. It felt like the whole thing had been pointing here.

What Surprised Me Most

God Spoke Through Passages I Normally Skip

Genealogies. Census numbers. Lists of territories and boundaries. Building plans for the tabernacle.

I expected to just push through those sections. And sometimes I did. But more than once, God stopped me in the middle of something I thought was just filler.

A name in a genealogy that had an extra detail. Something about the tabernacle that connected to something Jesus said. A census that reminded me that God sees and counts every single person.

Nothing in the Bible is filler. I knew that in my head. But reading it all in a month made me believe it in my gut.

The Bible Became One Story

This was the biggest shift. I stopped thinking of the Bible as 66 separate books and started experiencing it as one continuous story. Creation. Fall. Promise. Rescue. Failure. Promise again. Rescue again. And then Jesus, the church, good news.

The repetition of it hit me differently. God's patience is staggering. The number of times He could have walked away from Israel and didn't. The number of times He made a way when they had destroyed every way He had already given them. It's the same God on every page. And He doesn't give up.

The Transition to the New Testament Felt Different

This one surprised me the most.

When you read the Bible in a year, the transition from Malachi to Matthew just feels like turning to a new book. But when you read it in a month, it feels immediate.

I had just been reading about Israel under Babylonian and Persian rule. And suddenly I turned the page and they were under Roman rule. Centuries had passed, but it was obviously the same people. Still struggling. Still stubborn. Still looking for a deliverer. Still missing the point.

And there was Jesus. Walking into the middle of it.

It made me appreciate Him in a way I hadn't before. Not just as a Savior in the abstract, but as the answer to a story I had been reading for three and a half weeks. He was the promise fulfilled. And I had just read every chapter that led to Him.

Heather's Survival Guide

TIP #1

Schedule It

If you wait until you have time, you will never have time. Put two reading blocks on your calendar every day. Morning and evening. Set alarms if you have to. Treat this like an appointment you cannot cancel. Because the moment it becomes optional, it's the first thing that goes.

TIP #2

Read Morning and Night

Do not try to read all of your chapters in one sitting. Your brain will check out somewhere around chapter 20 and nothing after that will stick. Split it up. Read half in the morning and half at night. It is easier on your brain, and it keeps God's Word at the beginning and end of your day.

TIP #3

Put the Bible App Everywhere

Phone. Tablet. Computer. I had the Bible App open on everything I owned. You never know when you're going to get fifteen minutes. A doctor's office. A car line. A lunch break. Make sure you can pick up right where you left off from wherever you are.

Heather's Survival Guide

TIP #4

Read and Listen at the Same Time

This one changed everything for me. Whenever my mind started wandering, especially in genealogies or long legal sections, I would turn on the audio Bible and read along while listening. Keeping both my eyes and ears engaged helped me stay focused and keep moving. If you only take one tip from this guide, take this one.

TIP #5

Don't Get Behind

I cannot say this strongly enough. One day turns into two. Two turns into four. Four turns into quitting. This is the difference between reading the Bible in a month and saying you tried to read the Bible in a month. Every day matters. Do not let a single day slide.

TIP #6

Read Ahead When You Can

Some days you will finish your reading and still have energy. Do it. Keep going. Read ahead. I flew through Genesis and Exodus and thought, this is easy. And it was. Those early books move fast and the stories pull you in. So I kept reading. And I am so glad I did. Because when I hit Leviticus and Numbers, I had banked extra days. That cushion saved me. You will not always feel like reading ahead. But on the days you do, take advantage of it. Future you will be grateful.

Heather's Survival Guide

TIP #7

Use the Small Moments

Waiting rooms. Car lines. Commercial breaks. Ten minutes here and there makes a bigger difference than you think. I read entire books of the Bible standing in line at the grocery store. You do not need a quiet room with a candle. You just need your phone and five minutes.

TIP #8

Give Yourself Grace, Not Excuses

When you're reading the Bible in a year, missing a day is not a big deal. You catch up on Saturday and move on. But when you're reading the Bible in a month, every day matters. If you miss a day, don't beat yourself up about it. But don't let yourself off the hook either. Catch up immediately. Not tomorrow. Not this weekend. Today. Grace means you don't quit. It doesn't mean you coast.

TIP #9

Read the Bible Before You Read About the Bible

Podcasts are great. Devotionals are great. Bible studies are great. But for one month, spend more time reading God's Word than reading what someone else says about God's Word. Let the Holy Spirit speak to you directly through the text. You can go back to commentaries and study guides after. But for these 31 days, let it just be you and God and the Bible. You might be surprised how much He has to say when you're not filtering it through someone else's interpretation first.

The 31-Day Reading Plan

The Bible has 1,189 chapters. I grouped the readings by book so you are not stopping in the middle of a story. Some days are heavier than others but the actual reading time is more balanced than the chapter counts suggest. Psalms and Proverbs are short chapters. The epistles fly by. The Old Testament takes 25 days. The New Testament takes 6. Trust the plan.

DAY	READING	CHAPTERS
Day 1	Genesis 1-50	50 ch
Day 2	Exodus 1-40	40 ch
Day 3	Leviticus 1-27	27 ch
Day 4	Numbers 1-36	36 ch
Day 5	Deuteronomy 1-34	34 ch
Day 6	Joshua 1-24	24 ch
Day 7	Judges 1-21, Ruth 1-4	25 ch
Day 8	1 Samuel 1-31	31 ch
Day 9	2 Samuel 1-24	24 ch
Day 10	1 Kings 1-22	22 ch
Day 11	2 Kings 1-25	25 ch
Day 12	1 Chronicles 1-29	29 ch
Day 13	2 Chronicles 1-36	36 ch

The 31-Day Reading Plan

DAY	READING	CHAPTERS
Day 14	Ezra 1-10, Nehemiah 1-13, Esther 1-10	33 ch
Day 15	Job 1-42	42 ch
Day 16	Psalms 1-50	50 ch
Day 17	Psalms 51-100	50 ch
Day 18	Psalms 101-150	50 ch
Day 19	Proverbs 1-31, Ecclesiastes 1-12, Song of Solomon 1-8	51 ch
Day 20	Isaiah 1-33	33 ch
Day 21	Isaiah 34-66	33 ch
Day 22	Jeremiah 1-26	26 ch
Day 23	Jeremiah 27-52, Lamentations 1-5	31 ch
Day 24	Ezekiel 1-48, Daniel 1-12	60 ch

The 31-Day Reading Plan

DAY	READING	CHAPTERS
Day 25	Hosea through Malachi (12 books)	67 ch
Day 26	Matthew 1-28, Mark 1-16	44 ch
Day 27	Luke 1-24, John 1-21	45 ch
Day 28	Acts 1-28, Romans 1-16	44 ch
Day 29	1 Corinthians through Colossians	49 ch
Day 30	1 Thessalonians through Hebrews	35 ch
Day 31	James through Revelation	43 ch

Reading Tracker

Check off each day as you finish your reading. Watch the boxes fill up. By day 16, you are past the halfway mark. By day 26, you are in the New Testament. By day 31, you have read the entire Bible. You are doing this.

1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐	5 ☐	6 ☐	7 ☐
8 ☐	9 ☐	10 ☐	11 ☐	12 ☐	13 ☐	14 ☐
15 ☐	16 ☐	17 ☐	18 ☐	19 ☐	20 ☐	21 ☐
22 ☐	23 ☐	24 ☐	25 ☐	26 ☐	27 ☐	28 ☐
29 ☐	30 ☐	31 ☐				

10 Verses to Memorize

As you read through the Bible this month, let these ten verses settle into your heart. You will encounter each one along the way. When you get there, slow down for just a moment. Let it land.

VERSE 1

"Trust in the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways submit to him, and he will make your paths straight."

Proverbs 3:5-6 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 2

"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the Lord your God will be with you wherever you go."

Joshua 1:9 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 3

"But those who hope in the Lord will renew their strength. They will soar on wings like eagles; they will run and not grow weary, they will walk and not be faint."

Isaiah 40:31 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 4

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, plans to give you hope and a future."

Jeremiah 29:11 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 5

"I can do all this through him who gives me strength."

Philippians 4:13 (NIV)

VERSE 6

"The Lord is my shepherd, I lack nothing. He makes me lie down in green pastures, he leads me beside quiet waters, he refreshes my soul."

Psalm 23:1-3 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 7

"And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose."

Romans 8:28 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 8

"All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness, so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work."

2 Timothy 3:16-17 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 9

"Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path."

Psalm 119:105 (NIV)

Notes:

VERSE 10

"Let us not become weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up."

Galatians 6:9 (NIV)

Frequently Asked Questions

What translation did you use?

I used the NLT. It reads naturally and moves quickly, which matters when you are reading this much. If you are used to the NIV or ESV, those work too. I would avoid the KJV for this particular challenge simply because the older language slows you down. Use whatever translation helps you read the fastest without losing meaning.

Can I listen instead of read?

Yes. I did a combination of both. Most sections I read with my eyes. Some I listened to on audio. Some I did both at the same time. Whatever keeps you moving forward counts. There are no rules about how the words get into your brain. Just get them in there.

What if I start late in the month?

I say don't. Pick a month with 31 days, start on day one, and give yourself the full runway. Starting on the 5th means you already feel behind before you begin, and that is exactly the kind of pressure that makes people quit. Wait for the next 31-day month if you have to. But if you can start mid-month and go 31 days, then go for it.

What if I don't finish?

Then you read more of the Bible this month than you would have otherwise. That is not a failure. That is a win. But I will say this: most people who don't finish quit because they got behind and never caught up. If you stay on pace, you will finish. The reading plan works. Trust it.

Final Thoughts

One of my favorite things about reading the Bible in a month is that it reminds me whose story I am living in.

Before I focus on my goals.

Before I focus on my plans.

Before I focus on my challenges.

I spend a month focusing on God's story.

And every single time, I walk away reminded that the God who was faithful in Genesis is still faithful today.

He was faithful to Abraham when the promise seemed impossible.

He was faithful to Moses when the task seemed too big.

He was faithful to David when the enemy seemed too tall.

He was faithful to the Israelites even when they were not faithful to Him.

And He is faithful to you.

Right now. In whatever you are walking through.

I started this year with the word **intentional**. I wanted to be intentional about time in God's Word. And this challenge pushed me to do that in a way nothing else has.

So open your Bible. Start on Day 1. And let God remind you who He is.

You have got this.

And more importantly, He has got you.

The God who was faithful in Genesis is still faithful today.

Heather

Want to Keep *Going*?

Every Monday, Wednesday, and Friday I share Scripture reflections and real-life lessons on faith, leadership, and following God in the middle of it all.

If this guide encouraged you, come be part of the conversation.



HeatherLynWilson.com

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